



Resident Advisors Intercultural Learning & IDI Debrief *Toward Intercultural Growth & Community*

Beth Zemsky MAEd, LICSW
August 13, 2025

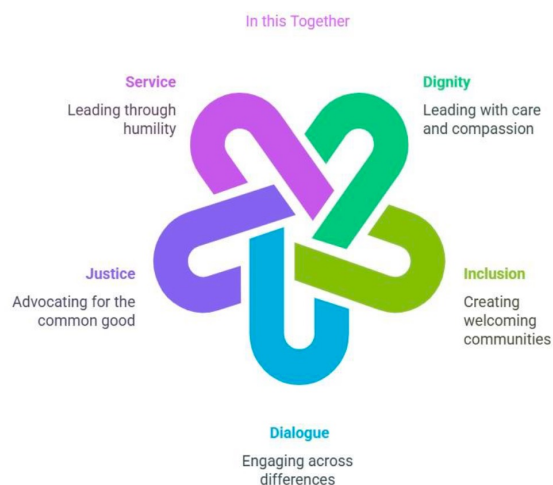
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Your Context: In This Together

Rooted in our Catholic values, built for community.



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An Activity



An activity....

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Differences create ...

Nothing ...

&

Everything...

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Intercultural Competency

- Developmental
- How we make sense of our experience
- Capacity to experience commonalities and differences with increasing complexity
- Capacity to shift behavior and mindset based on the cultural context = *Adaptation & Cultural Agility*

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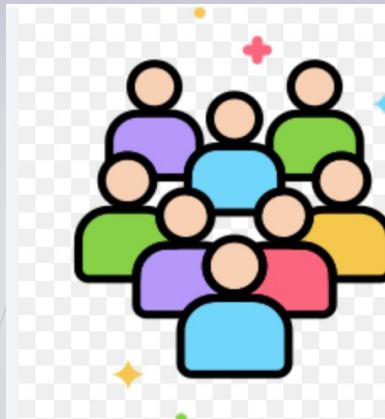
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Diversity:

The differences that make a difference

- *Numerical representation of differing of people, viewpoints, experiences*
- *Count the people*



Planning Question: What are some of the “differences that may make a difference” in your context?

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Inclusion:

Embracing differences

▪ *Actions, Behaviors, Policies & Practices* that support the differing experiences, & perspectives of “diverse” people being taken into account

▪ *The People Count*

Planning Question: How do we make sure we are taking differing experiences and perspectives into account in our decision-making and program planning?

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Equity

Addresses the disparity of resources and how they are structurally allocated to marginalized communities

- Resources include money, power, access, information, human resources, etc.
- Outcomes focused. Geared to ameliorating the disparities caused by structural and systemic impediments to access and opportunity

(The outcomes count)

Planning Question: What are the outcome you seek? For whom?

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Universal Design

An approach to integrating equity & justice

- A concept from Disability Rights Movement ...
- *By designing something for those who are most marginalized, we design something that actually benefits everyone.*
- Key is to determine who is most marginalized, determine their needs, and then design strategies utilizing an equity lens to increase access or remove structural barriers.

Universal Design Related Planning Question:

- Who is currently most marginalized in this context?
- How do we hold these people and communities at the center of our planning?

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Culture...

...is about shared patterns that help us make meaning of our environment and determine appropriate behavior.

“It’s just the way we do things around here”

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Intercultural Competency

- Deeper cultural self-understanding
How one makes sense of and respond to cultural differences in terms of one's own culturally learned perceptions, values and practices
- Deeper cultural other-understanding
Different ways people from other cultural groups make sense of and respond to cultural difference

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Rooted in Dignity

Core Value: Care & Compassion

- Leading with care and compassion means acknowledging the sacredness of every person and responding to their needs with empathy.
- It is rooted in the Catholic belief that each individual is made in the image of God and deserves to be treated with dignity and love.
- Reminds us to uphold and honor the dignity of all people in our daily actions.

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Rooted in Dignity

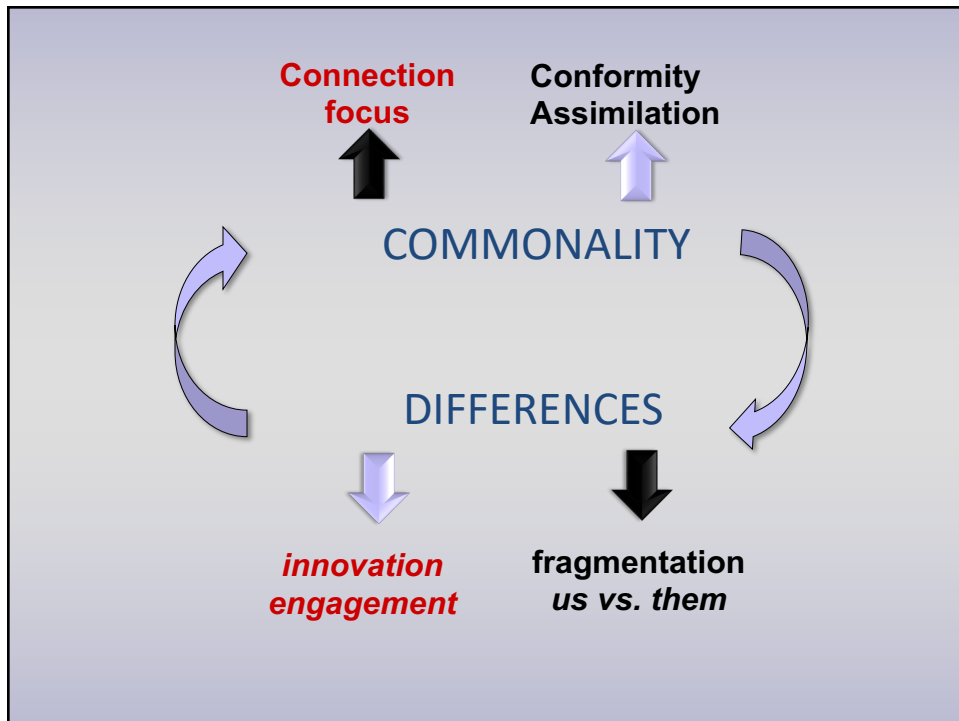
Self-reflection:

- Who taught you what dignity looks like in action?
- Share about a time when someone treated you with deep care and respect?
 - What did they do?
 - What about it felt respectful to you?

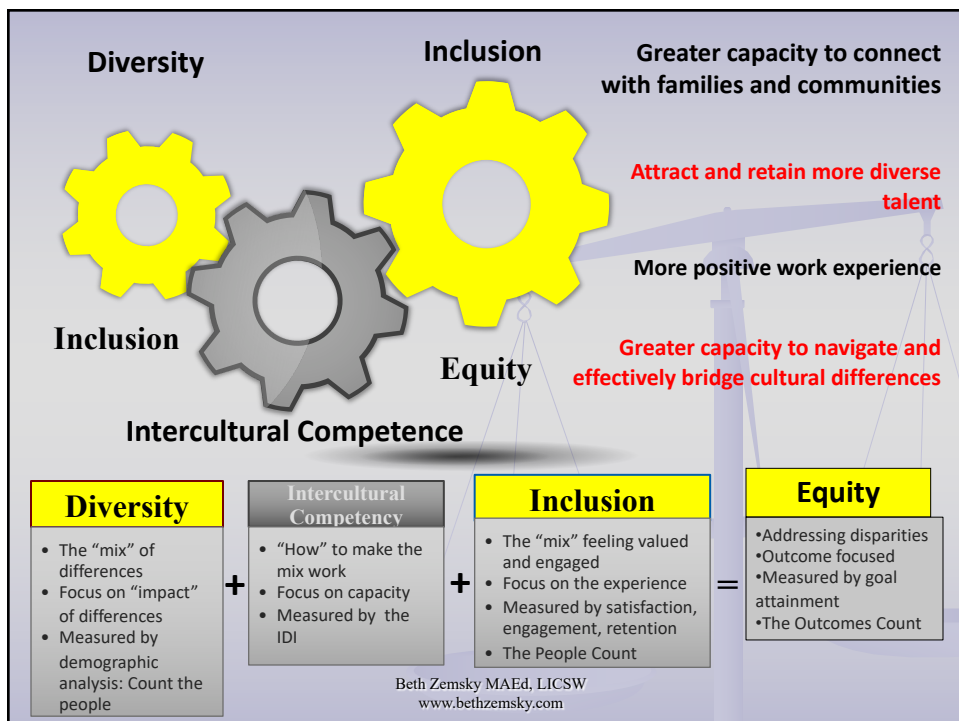
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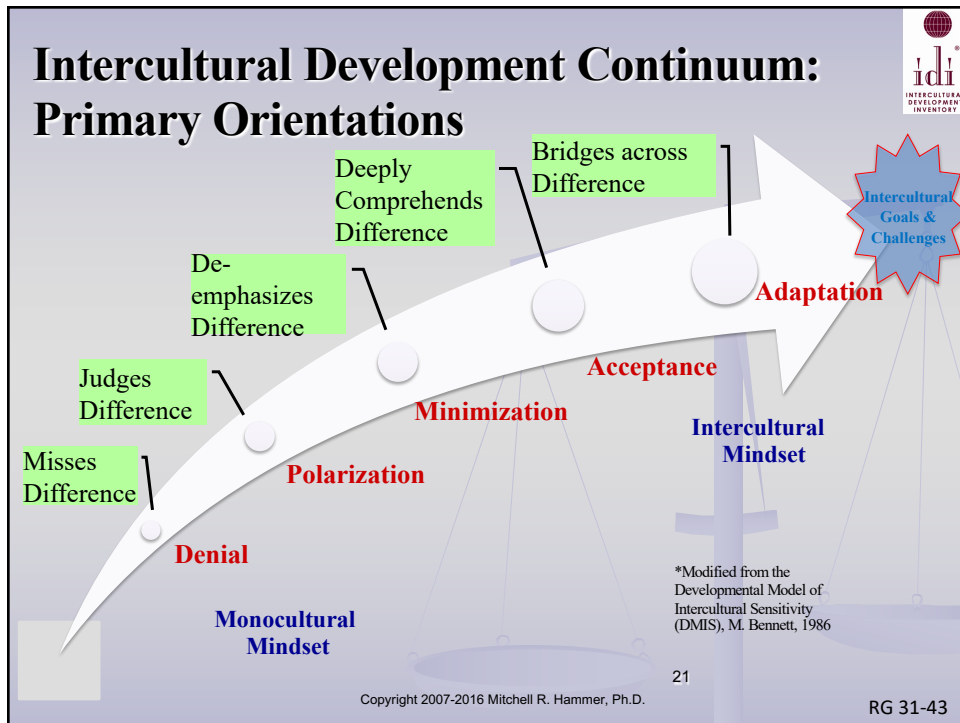
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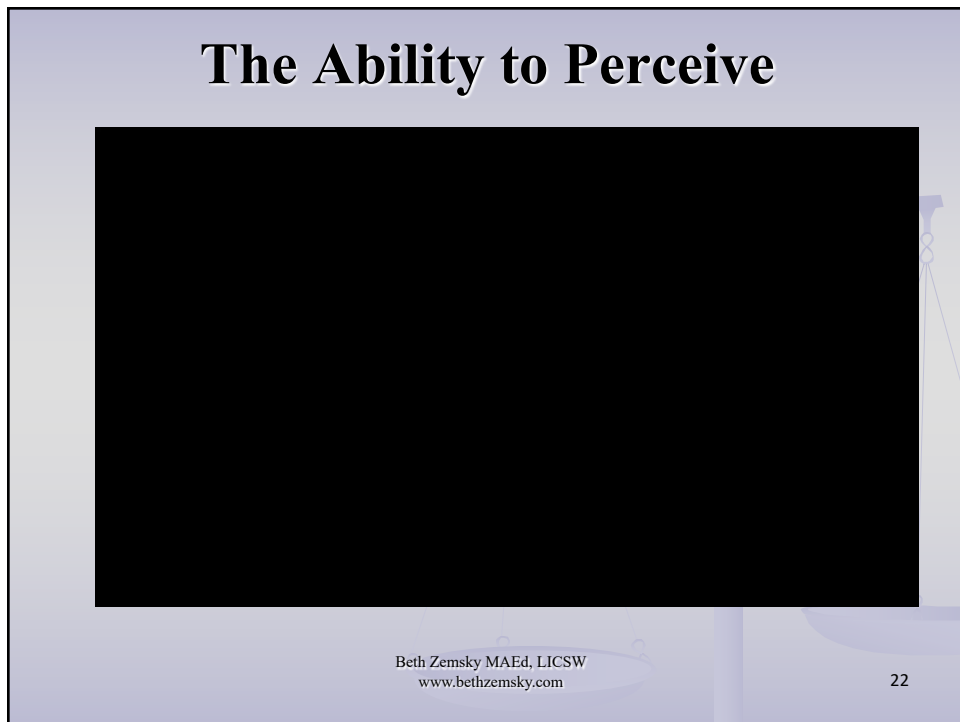
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The Power of Perspective

“We cannot see what is ‘out there’ merely by looking around. Everything depends on the lenses through which we view the world. By putting on new lenses, we can see things that would otherwise remain invisible.”

Parker Palmer

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Rooted in Dignity

Reflect:

- What does it mean to honor someone’s dignity when you disagree or don’t understand their perspective?

Scenario Practice:

Imagine a student is upset after feeling ignored in a group meeting. As a student leader, how would you respond with empathy?

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“Well, I guess I’ ll have the ham and eggs”



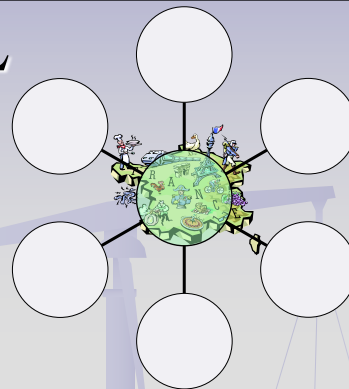
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DENIAL

Inability to See Differences

- Comfortable with, and seek out, the familiar
- “My culture is the only reality”
- Benign intent & neglect
- Privilege

Primary emotional/cognitive approach
Indifference



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DENIAL

Organizational Impact

Issues of diversity, inclusion ignored
One size fits all

Perception of Best Practices

Tradition

Primary Learning Emphasis

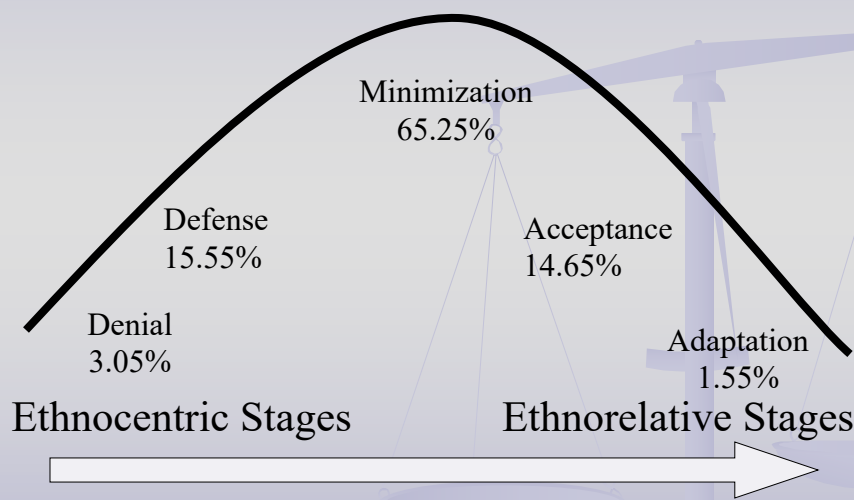
Cultural Awareness
Begin to notice cultural differences

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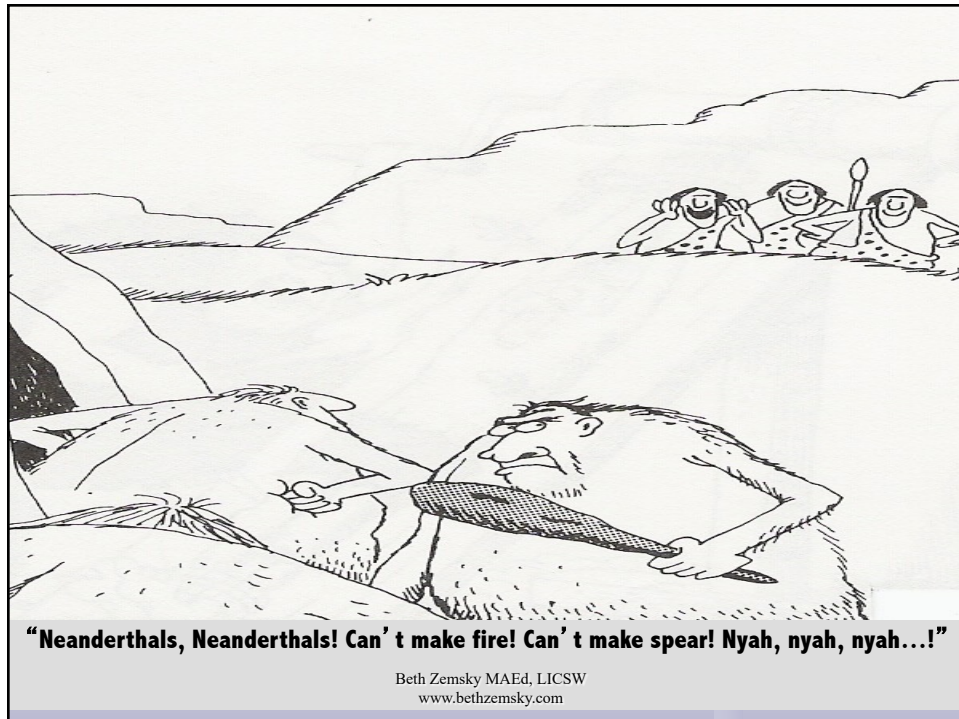
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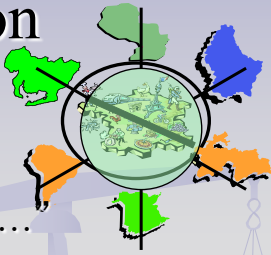
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DEFENSE/Polarization

Dualistic – “Us vs. Them”

- Denigration/Superiority “Those people...”
- Strong commitment to own worldview
- Some distrust of different behavior or ideas
- Recognition of difference coupled with negative evaluation
- Perception of threat to belief or way of life

Primary emotional/cognitive approach
Fear & anger



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DEFENSE

Organizational Impact

Diversity & inclusion seen as problems and obstacles
Same-culture segregation based on perceived need for protection
Backlash - Policy and practice retrenchment

Perception of Best Practice

Use of “expert” data that overemphasizes risk & cost and differences between own group and others

- Confirmation Bias
- Backfire Effect

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DEFENSE

Exercise of Power

Denial of the consequences of discrimination and opposition to attempts to provide equal opportunity and other efforts to remedy past discrimination

”Blame the victim” mentality

Overemphasis on use of Coercive power

Primary Developmental Learning Tasks

Finding commonalities where people think none exist

Cooperative activities, team building, processes to support discovering shared needs & goals

Key Developmental Question

How do I find anything in common between me and them?

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Challenges in Creating Shared Meaning

- Assumptions
- Meanings are in people, not in words.
- Perception trumps intention.
- We tend to see things not as they are, but as we are.

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REVERSAL

Dualistic: *Them vs. Us*

■ Reverses the us/them polarization:

- “They” seen as superior, “we” are stereotyped in negative ways
- Overemphasis on the difference between oneself & some part of one’s own identity group

■ Internalized oppression

■ Performative Allies

Primary emotional/cognitive approach

■ Shame

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REVERSAL

Primary Developmental Learning Tasks

Recognize stereotypical nature of one’s perceptions

Explore commonalities with own identity group

Develop more complex lens with which own identity group(s) are viewed

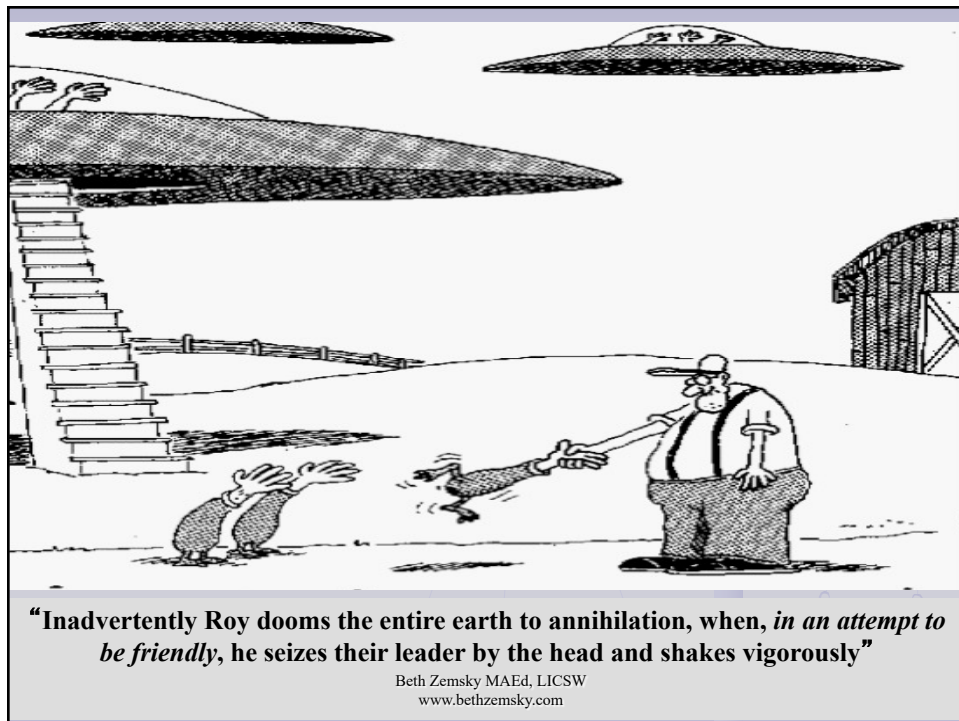
Key Developmental Question

Can I view my own identities with more complexity?

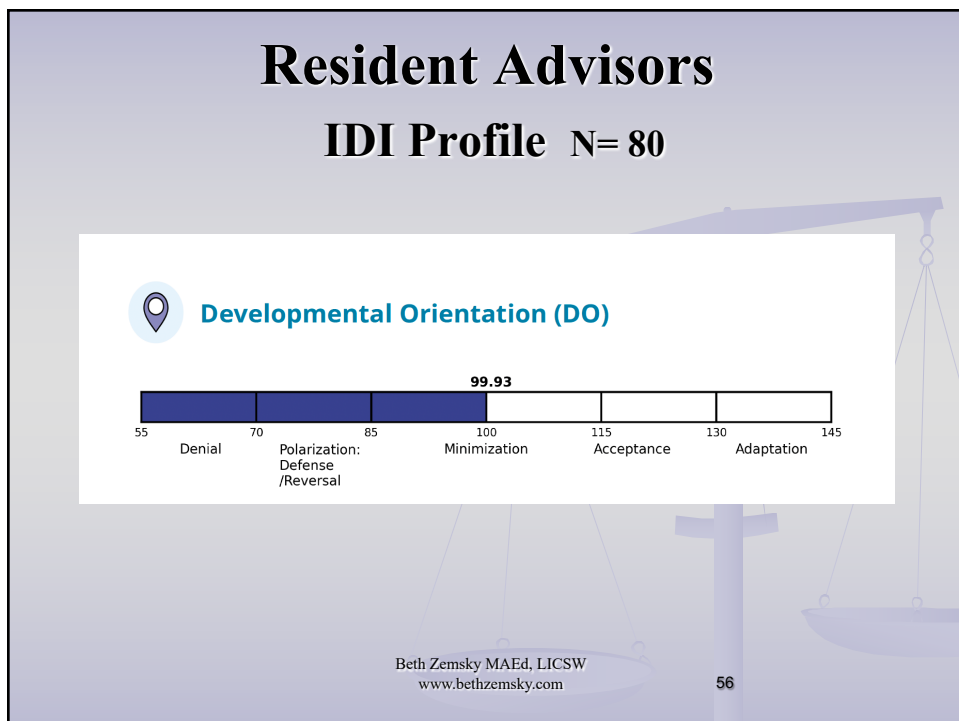
Can I find commonality with the people and/or qualities I’d rather disavow?

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MINIMIZATION

Overemphasis on Commonality & Similarity

- *Minimize* differences
- Comfortable - (insistently nice)
- Don't denigrate; also avoid stereotypes
- Moved beyond feeling of culture as threat
- "Deep down, we're all the same"
- Use on cultural lens as reference
- Project cultural lens & assumptions on others

Primary emotional/cognitive approach
Comfort & Tolerance

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MINIMIZATION

Organizational Impact

- Hire for difference, onboard for similarity due to emphasis on comfort & fit with dominant culture
- Pressure to assimilate to the dominant culture
- Implicit bias that contributes to micro-aggressions
- Conflict avoidant
- Organizational processes designed from perspective of, and to support, current organizational culture
- Want change ... without changing anything about ourselves

Perception of Best Practices

- Use of "expert" data that assesses generally accepted/dominate cultural standards

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MINIMIZATION

Exercise of Power

Acceptance of institutionalized privilege

Overemphasis on use of Positional Power

Primary Developmental Learning Tasks

- Increasing cultural self-awareness
- For dominant culture: managing feelings of guilt, emotional discomfort, dissonance, and anxiety in dealing head on with issues concerning racism and other forms of oppression.
- For non-dominant culture: re-grounding in own identity and cultural self-awareness

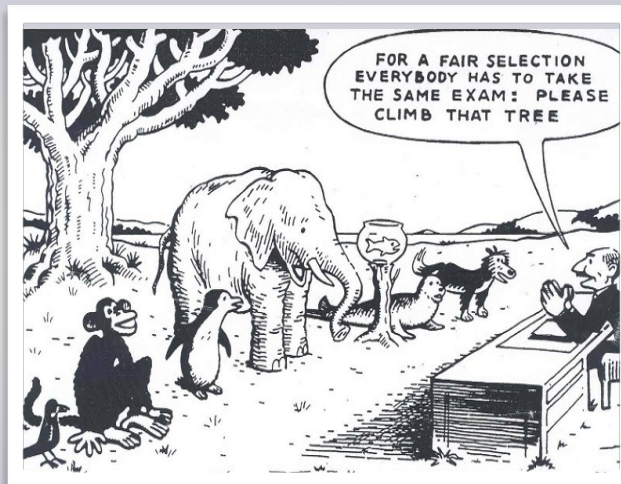
Key Developmental Questions

- How do I take responsibility for my cultural lens?
- How do I see what I currently don't see?

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What Does Minimization Look Like



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In Intercultural Contexts...

Shared meaning can not be assumed

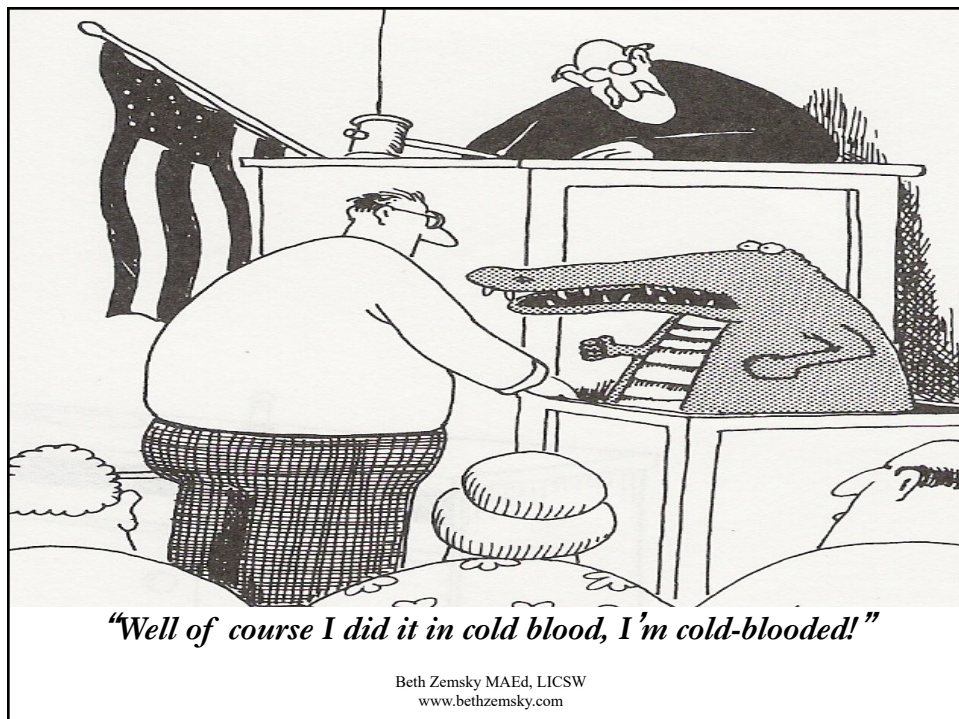
Shared meaning must be:

- Discovered
- Negotiated
- Created

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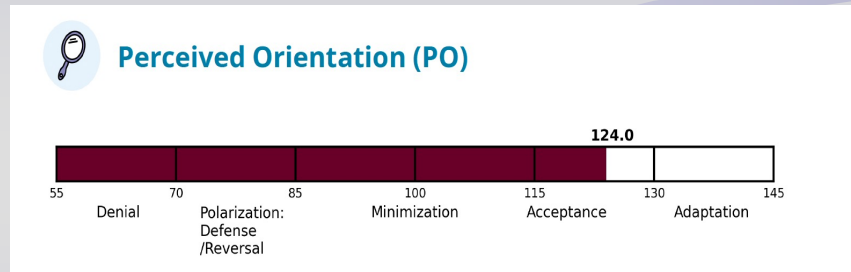
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ACCEPTANCE

Recognize cultural patterns & able to see them in context

- Begin to explore cultural differences
- Non-evaluative curiosity about other cultures
- “More difference means more creative ideas!”
- Behavioral Relativism: All behavior exists in cultural context
- Value Relativism: Beliefs and values exist in cultural context

Primary emotional/cognitive approach

- Curiosity



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ACCEPTANCE

Organizational Impact

- Curiosity and exploration
- Cognitive understanding of cultural perspectives of some cultures
- Talking talk without integrated walk

Best Practice

- Community based assessments and research

Primary Learning Emphasis

- Culturally specific information coupled with practical application. Practice!!!
- Ability to maintain ethical commitment in the face of relativity.

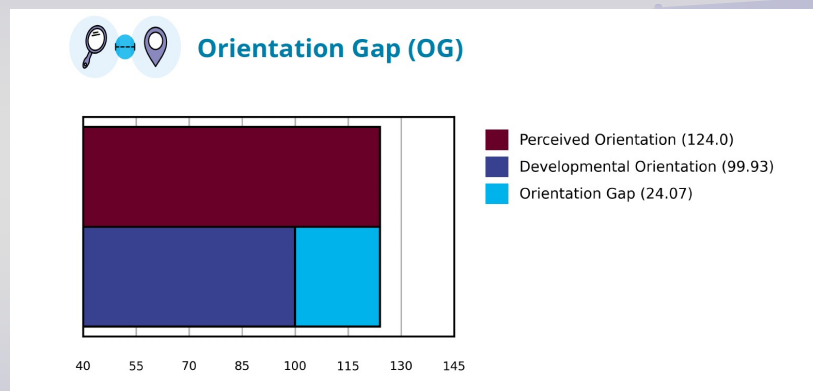
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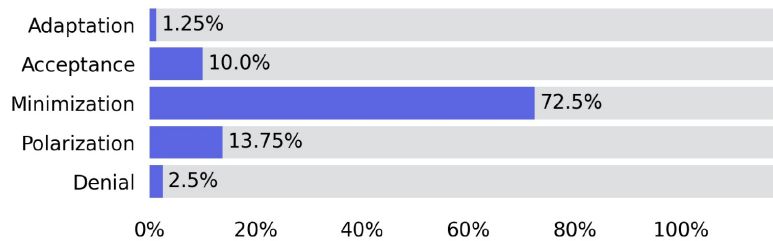
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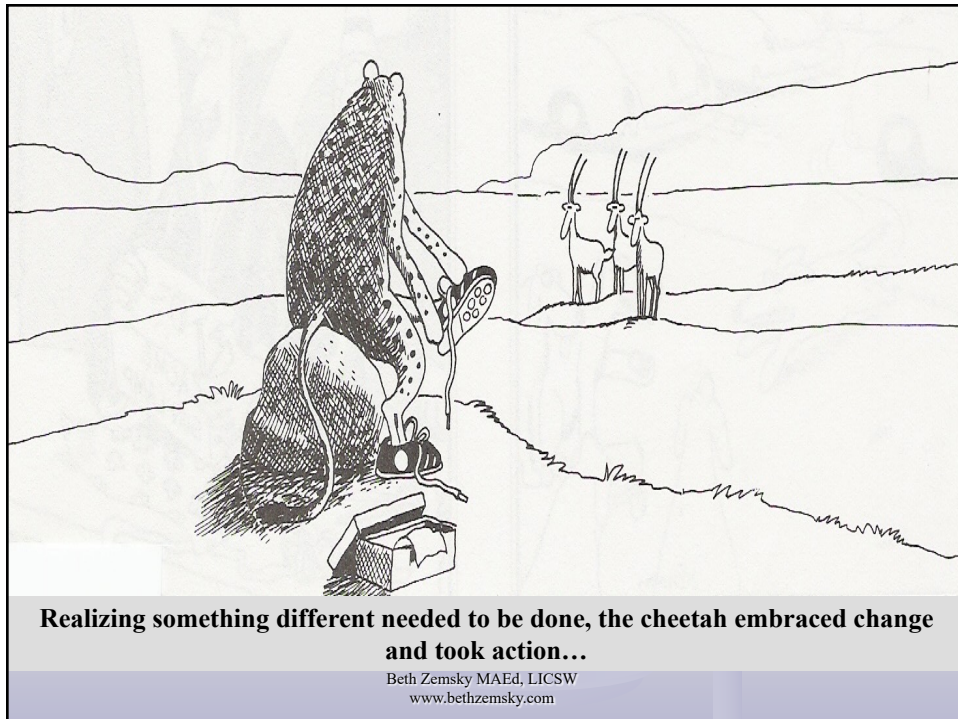
Range of Developmental Orientations



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Adaptation

Mindset: *Ability to shift perspective...*

- Cultural self awareness & curiosity
- Development of empathy & analysis
- ... While maintaining own identity and values

Skillset: *Behavioral Code Shifting*

- Development of communication skills that enable mutually beneficial interactions across culture
- Ability to shift behavior based on context

Primary emotional/cognitive approach

- Flexibility & tolerance for ambiguity

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ADAPTATION

- What is our goal?
- What is our role in relation to this goal?
- What do we do without losing our soul?

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